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Change Management and Release Policy: VI Business (India)

1. Executive Purpose and Document Scope

The Change Management and Release Policy dictates the standardized life cycle protocols for all infrastructure, application, and network modifications within the VI Business (India) enterprise ecosystem. The primary objective is to enable rapid service evolution and customer provisioning while structurally minimizing the risk of unpredicted service outages that violate enterprise Service Level Agreements (SLAs).

This document aligns strictly with ITIL v4 principles and the ISO/IEC 20000-1:2018 (IT Service Management) framework audited annually across our Pune and Mumbai Tier-III core operations centers.

2. Definitions, Assumptions, and Applicability

Definitions:

- **CAB:** Change Advisory Board.
- **eCAB:** Emergency Change Advisory Board.
- **RFC:** Request for Change.
- **MW:** Maintenance Window.

Assumptions:

- All changes are systematically logged within the central enterprise ITSM platform (ServiceNow) under the `Change_Request` taxonomy.
- The "Customer Network" ends at the terminating Customer Premises Equipment (CPE). Changes beyond the LAN port of the CPE are out of scope unless explicitly covered under a fully-managed LAN/WLAN contractual addendum.

Applicability:

- **Scope:** All core network elements (Optical, IP-MPLS, 5G Core), enterprise mobility platforms (cAPN routers), SD-WAN Orchestrators, and outward-facing API Gateways.
- **Audience:** RFP Writers, Solutions Architects, NOC/SOC Engineers, and Enterprise Quality Auditors.

3. Change Categories and Classification

Changes are classified into four distinct tiers based on risk, scope, and urgency. This classification dictates the approval workflow and lead time requirements.

Category	Definition	Example	Minimum Lead Time
Standard (Pre-Approved)	Low-risk, highly documented, and frequently executed tasks with proven track records.	Activating a new SD-WAN branch logic template via zero-touch provisioning (ZTP).	None (Auto-approved upon logging).
Normal (Minor)	Low-to-medium risk. Does not require dedicated outage windows but needs peer review.	Updating non-core router firewall rules or modifying API rate-limit configurations.	3 Business Days
Normal (Major)	High-risk modifications requiring a scheduled outage or spanning multiple core nodes.	Upgrading the firmware on the primary Mumbai SD-WAN Orchestrator cluster.	14 Business Days
Emergency	Immediate modifications required to resolve a Priority 1 (P1) incident or mitigate zero-day security vulnerabilities.	Applying a critical zero-day patch to the Fortinet SOC firewall clusters.	As Soon As Possible (ASAP)

4. The Change Advisory Board (CAB) Process

The CAB acts as the cross-functional gating authority for all Normal (Minor & Major) changes.

4.1 CAB Composition

- **Chair:** Enterprise Change Manager
- **Mandatory Attendees:** Representatives from Network Planning, Operations (NOC Level 3), Enterprise Security (SOC), and Customer Success Management.

4.2 Review Criteria

During the weekly CAB (held every Tuesday at 14:00 IST), each RFC is scrutinized for:

1. **Technical Feasibility:** Has the change been tested in the staging environment?
2. **Risk Assessment:** What is the impact blast radius if the change fails?
3. **Conflict Avoidance:** Does the proposed Maintenance Window overlap with another major core upgrade or a customer's business-critical period (e.g., e-commerce client during Diwali sales)?

5. Emergency Change Handling (eCAB)

When a P1 incident threatens to breach a 99.99% availability SLA, standard lead times are suspended.

- **Workflow:** The Incident Commander initiates an eCAB bridge call.
- **Approval:** Requires verbal approval from the National Head of Network Operations and the Enterprise CISO (or their designated duty deputies).
- **Post-Mortem:** All Emergency changes must have a formal RFC retrospectively logged in ServiceNow within 24 hours to ensure audit compliance.

6. Rollback Expectations (Back-Out Plans)

No Normal or Emergency change is authorized without a comprehensively documented and tested rollback plan.

- **Requirement:** The RFC must detail the exact commands or automation scripts required to revert the system to its pre-change state.
- **Trigger:** If the change execution breaches the allocated Maintenance Window (MW) by >15 minutes without successful completion, the execution engineer *must* abort and immediately initiate the rollback sequence.

7. Maintenance Communication and Windows

To respect enterprise operating hours across Indian verticals, strict boundaries govern execution timing and customer notification.

7.1 Standard Maintenance Windows

- **Core Infrastructure:** Sundays between 01:00 IST and 05:00 IST.
- **Customer Edge (CPE):** Negotiated per customer, defaulting to Saturdays between 23:00 IST and 03:00 IST.

7.2 Communication SLA

- **Normal (Major) Changes:** Customers receive automated portal notifications and standardized email alerts at T-10 days, T-24 hours, and immediately upon MW completion.
- **Emergency Changes:** Out-of-band communication (SMS and dedicated AM calls) to affected customer technical contacts within 30 minutes of eCAB approval.

8. Evidence and Logging Requirements

To satisfy ISO 20000 and SOC 2 Type II audit requirements, strict digital chain-of-custody rules apply.

- **Peer Review:** The engineer executing the change cannot be the same engineer who authored the RFC or approved the CAB ticket.
- **Configuration Backups:** Automated pre-change and post-change configuration snapshots are archived immutably in the central Rancid/Oxidized repositories.

9. Constraints, Exclusions, and Dependencies

- **Third-Party Vendors:** Changes executed by OEM partners (e.g., Cisco, Fortinet resident engineers) on behalf of VI Business remain strictly governed by this internal SOP.
- **Client Self-Service:** Configurations altered by enterprise admins via the VI Self-Care portal (e.g., updating IoT SIM APNs) are considered 'Standard Changes' and bypass CAB, implicitly carrying the customer's own risk acceptance.

10. Proposal-Use Guidance

- **"How do you ensure stability during upgrades?"** Cite Section 4 (CAB Process) and Section 6 (Rollback Expectations) to prove rigorous gating.
- **SLA Defense:** Explicitly state that planned Maintenance Windows (in adherence with Section 7) are *excluded* from SLA uptime calculations and penalty formulas.

11. Governance and Ownership

- **Owner:** National Head of ITSM
- **Reviewers:** Operations Head, CEBO

- **Update Cadence:** Annual, aligned with post-audit remediation cycles.